

Episode 62: Once Upon a Time... (40) – The Beginning of Days with Theatrical *Dragon Ball Z*

The Beijing Olympics have begun.

As expected from the world's highest level sports competition all gathering at the Olympics, each match is incredible. So regardless of whether Japanese athletes are competing or not, I've been watching quite a variety.

With Beijing being just one hour time difference, it's difficult to watch live broadcasts during convenient times. So inevitably it's mainly late-night NHK-BS digests and reruns. Hence I'm somewhat sleep-deprived (bitter laugh).

There are competition events I'm seeing for the first time, which is refreshing. I watched archery and badminton matches for the first time. Hockey was incredibly speedy and quite appealing.

Among all this, what I'm watching with "professional eyes" is swimming.

The eternal theme for those doing colour direction is, above all, expressing "water." Recently it's often processed with 3D CG, but expressing "water" through animation + colouring is still anime's foundation. So while enjoying the competitions, I'm just looking at water (laugh).

The texture of undulating pool water surfaces, the splashes athletes kick up, underwater bubbles, diving water columns, and the colour tones of athletes underwater, and so on. The more I look, the more interesting it becomes (laugh).

The broadcast technology is amazing too. Between the camera work and CG-combined explanatory composite screens, I'm quite enjoying that side too!

Come to think of it, I remember the men's gymnastics team final from the previous Athens Olympics. At that time, I was watching while working at Oizumi Studio in the early morning. I watched that famous "Bridge to Glory" commentary on the master monitor at my desk (connected to a VCR, so you could watch TV through its tuner).

Hmm? What work was that? Saint Seiya? ...I mean, it feels like recent memory... (sweat).
Well then.

The clock goes back not just four years, but quite far. Continuing the old stories (laugh).

1990-91 centered on OVA work, but OVAs continued in 1992 too with *BE-BOP HIGHSCHOOL* 3 (director Kakudo Hiroyuki, animation director Hayama Jun'ichi) and the previously mentioned *Crying Freeman* 5: *Senjou no Kishimojin*.

In between all this, I became involved in new work. Theatrical *Dragon Ball Z* productions.

Dragon Ball TV series began in 1986, followed by *Dragon Ball Z* from 1989. Both were huge hits and extremely popular, and around that time, theatrical works were being made at a pace of two per year for the spring and summer "Toei Manga Festival." I was assigned to handle the March 1992 release *Dragon Ball Z: Clash! The 10 Billion Power Warriors* (激突!!100億パワーの戦士たち).

"Huh? *Dragon Ball*? Me? Why?" I remember responding like that when the department manager assigned it to me. Somehow it was suddenly decided I'd do it.

At the time, Toei had a principle that theatrical versions of TV series works would in principle have the TV's main person handle colour direction. However, this *Dragon Ball Z* worked differently from other TV series.

For example, like me with *Saint Seiya*, normally one colour director would be assigned to a series, creating main character colours and managing colour direction sheets, but this *Dragon Ball* team didn't assign a dedicated colour director. Staff room members - chief director, directors, and assistant directors - decided all colour direction matters, with production coordinators and assistant directors managing colour direction. They'd give colour direction decided in the staff room directly to finishing production companies for work. That was roughly the system.

This team had used this method since the original *Dr. Slump*. Well, for TV series, especially works where characters don't increase much, this method worked somehow (← but later this method backfired when colour directions got scattered (bitter laugh)).

However, for theatrical works, you can't do everything "in the staff room" like TV. So nominally, a female colour director named Sakai-san had been handling *Dragon Ball* theatrical works as the basic person in charge, having worked on previous *Dragon Ball* and *Dragon Ball Z* theatrical versions.

So somehow this *Dragon Ball Z* work came to me. This was November 1991.

Honestly, I had hardly watched *Dragon Ball* original or TV until then. I had read the *Dr. Slump* original and watched quite a bit of TV since it was the first work I coloured when I started anime work as a part-timer, but I knew almost nothing about *Dragon Ball* (bitter laugh).

So I first read the original comics in bulk to get "basic knowledge" in my head (laugh).

Most TV series theatrical versions become "side story" tales separate from the TV series. This *Dragon Ball Z: Clash! The 10 Billion Power Warriors* was like that too. So it seemed I didn't necessarily need to worry about matching TV.

Still, it was a popular work's theatrical version, and the director was the renowned Nishio Daisuke. The animation director was Maeda Minoru. Quite nervously, I went to greet the theatrical staff room... But no one was there (sweat). I went again on another day but still no one. I heard "they haven't been coming recently." Apparently they were holed up at home working on storyboards. Oh, come to think of it, I hadn't received the storyboard... it wasn't finished yet? (sweat)

The time was mid-November 1991. Theatrical release was March 7th the following year. Work time was already under three months. "Ah, I see. Because of these circumstances, things became difficult, so it came to me..."

My long relationship with the *Dragon Ball Z* theatrical series, which would continue from then on, began like this.

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